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My family paid \$21 to take our car on a ferry through Washington. It was better than our \$300 whale-watching boat tour.

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We found our inexpensive ferry ride through Washington had as many beautiful views and wildlife sightings as our pricey whale-watching tour.

- My family loves the ferry system in Washington, thanks to its affordable pricing and stunning views.
- Recently, we took a budget-friendly ferry ride from Olympic National Park to Whidbey Island.
- Wildlife sightings during the \$21 [car-ferry ride](#) were better than ones on our whale-watching tour.

Washington is one of my [family's favorite travel destinations](#). We've visited the state several times, and we keep returning to explore more of its beauty. On each visit, we include a ferry journey to see scenic barrier islands in [Puget Sound](#). Here's why we love these ferry-based expeditions — and why a recent one to Whidbey Island really blew us away.

Over the years, my family has enjoyed stunning vistas from Washington's ferries.

If you want to see a nice view of Washington, try a ferry ride. When my son was younger, we used rides on Washington's ferries as sightseeing excursions. On a clear day, the [ferry between Seattle and Bainbridge Island](#) offers unmatched views of the city's skyline. Its price tag — about \$10 per adult, kids are free — also makes it much more affordable than seeing the city on a land-based tour.

On a recent visit to Olympic National Park, we took a ferry to an island with great views and access to outdoor adventures.



We took a ferry out of Olympic National Park. Now that my son is a tween, he loves more active adventures. While planning a recent hiking trip through Washington's Olympic Peninsula, we decided nearby [Whidbey Island](#) would be the perfect place to extend our stay and enjoy even more sightseeing and other outdoor activities. To get there from Olympic National Park, we would take a ferry that allowed us to take our rental car with us.

The ferry ride from Olympic National Park to Whidbey Island only cost us \$21.



We drove our car onto the ferry. To get from the park to Whidbey Island, we took the ferry from Port Townsend to Coupeville. I booked the ferry passage online for my three-person family and our rental car and was pleasantly surprised to see that our one-way trip was only \$21. Driving onto the ferry was a smooth, well-organized process that only took a few minutes.

Once parked on the ferry, we weren't confined to our car.

From the deck, we were able to spot seabirds and seals. Once our car was all set, we headed up to the ship's deck area. The ferry's great indoor and outdoor sightseeing options allowed us to view birds, seals, and other wildlife. We also enjoyed watching Washington's rugged landscape pass us by. The ship also had a small snack shop, where my son purchased chips and a sports drink.

We had a great time once we docked, too.



Whidbey Island was fun to explore. After about 30 minutes, we docked at Whidbey Island, which also proved to be a great spot for sightseeing and wildlife viewing. First, we explored downtown Coupeville's cute boutiques, art galleries, and restaurants. From the town pier, we spotted even more seals swimming close to shore. At one point, we passed a printed guide showcasing whales in the region next to a bell to ring if any were spotted. After eating some fresh seafood, we drove about 30 minutes to Deception Pass State Park.

While on the island, we continued to immerse ourselves in nature.



Deception Pass State Park was beautiful. The island's picturesque state park also offered ample wildlife viewing opportunities. At Deception Pass State Park, our one-day parking pass was only \$10. My family had lots of time to explore, birdwatch, hike, paddle, and soak up the scenery.

Lastly, we did a pricey whale-watching tour that paled in comparison to our affordable ferry ride.



We weren't super sold on the whale-watching tour, especially since we'd seen wildlife from our cheap ferry ride. Wildlife sightings on land or a ferry are never guaranteed, so I'd also booked us a \$300 [whale-watching tour](#). Our tour was on the "mainland," so we drove up the bridge on the north end of Whidbey Island to get to the boat. It took us to [San Juan Islands](#), an archipelago known for its orca-watching opportunities. Unfortunately, we only saw one orca during our four-hour excursion. It was beautiful, but the whale's distance from us, combined with the numerous other tour boats in the area all vying for a prime viewing position, made the experience feel crowded and sort of artificial.

After this tour, I realized we preferred the more natural and spontaneous feeling of encountering wildlife during our ferry ride. We actually saw more animals from the ferry than we did on the tour. Even if we hadn't, we would've still gotten to enjoy beautiful scenery as we sailed through Washington. Spotting animals in the wild can be unpredictable, so I'd rather take my chances on a laid-back, inexpensive ferry instead of pricey excursions where tourists compete for the best views.